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an impact on various sectors including oil and gas, health-care, energy, space, defence, digital media, manufacturing, etc, stated Sethu Vijayakumar, professor and director of the Institute of Perception, Action and Behaviour (IPAB) at the University of Edinburgh's School of Informatics.

Vijayakumar said that advancement of robotics technology would move in a pioneering way to reduce burden of labour by using joint working arrangements in different sectors such as manufacturing and assistive surgery. The recent developments in robotics technology include analytical planning, using episodic memory and enhanced manipulation skills, *Business Line* reported.

Here comes a light-weight robotic hand

Human-like robotic hand would now no longer be limited to the realm of science fiction, thanks to a key breakthrough made by German scientists. The team has announced the development of a versatile bionic hand that can pick up objects almost like human fingers.



Bionic hand developed by German scientists

The fingers are made of soft materials including silicone and rubber. The scientists said they are inflated with compressed air, thus making them different from traditional electromechanical actuators built of motors, gears, joints and links. The bionic hand was unveiled at the Robotics Science and Systems (RSS) conference at Berlin Technical University where Ph.D student Raphael Deimel gave a demonstration of the new robotic hand.

"The vision is that one day robots can help people in their everyday (tasks)," the student said. "They could bring things from A to B for example, look for the lost keys or clean rooms," he added. But before this can become a reality, robots must be able to pick things up without crushing them. Controlled via a computer, the sensitive robotic hand can grasp various objects of different sizes, shapes and textures. Interestingly, the hand can also help determine how hard the fingers grasp depending on the size of the object. "The hand doesn't require any sensor technology," said Deimel. Moreover, it can pick up objects such as pens, sunglasses, bottles and clothes.